

Emergency Decision Unit Pathway

Rib fracture

Date DD/MM/YY

Patient details

Full name

DoB

Unit number

(use sticker if available)

Inclusion criteria	Adults with a confirmed rib fracture who are unsuitable for immediate discharge from ED due to • Age 65 or above • Clinical frailty score (CFS) 5 or above • Pain insufficiently controlled • Unable to manage at home
Exclusion criteria	• Need for admission to a bed-holding specialty due to significant illness or additional injuries • Persistently abnormal vital signs or test results (e.g. high WCC, newly abnormal U&Es or acid-base disturbance on blood gas) • Hypotension at any time • Fever at any time • Rib fractures requiring a higher level of care (see main 'UHL rib fracture in adults guideline') • Flail chest • Three or more rib fractures (NB: if aged 65 or above: two or more rib fractures) • Chest drain in situ • Lung contusion • New oxygen requirement • Chronic respiratory disease or heart failure • BMI 40 or more

Notes to doctor completing this pathway (ED senior to ensure compliance)

- This pathway must only be used in conjunction with the ED proforma '[Rib fracture management in adults](#)'
- If required, use it in conjunction with additional EDU pathways
- Prescribe appropriate medicines from the ED formulary; go to NC Meds > Emergency Medicine (ED)

EDU plan

- Regular analgesia (if persistent severe pain, consider oxycodone)
- RADS (OT/PT rapid assessment and discharge service) review (daily 08–18:00; call **07950 883 651**)
- Provide with [Chest injury PIL](#) on discharge

NB:

- If severe pain remains an issue, refer to thoracic surgical team – will need regional anaesthesia or PCA
- Notify COTW (out of hours: EPIC) if NEWS increasing / clinical deterioration / OT or Physio concerned
- Admit to appropriate speciality if not ready for discharge within 48h (revisit ED proforma '[Rib fracture management in adults](#)' for guidance)

Planned & agreed by

Print name

Signature

Referring Clinician

NB: Pathway must be completed and signed by the referring clinician. Once agreed, the EPIC or an ED consultant must record 'EDU admission on rib fracture pathway approved' in the 'ED Flow Notes' box on Nervecentre.

Patients will NOT be accepted to EDU until this has been done